

ATTACKING PEARL HARBOR

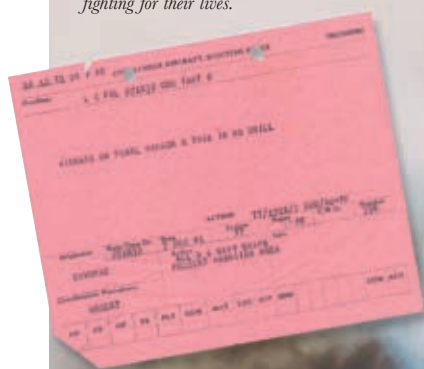


TIME FOR ACTION

Japanese sailors stand by watching as a Mitsubishi Zero takes off from their flight deck. Seaman Iki Kikumoto, on the carrier Akagi, said of the attack on Pearl Harbor: "An air attack on Hawaii! A dream come true!"

"THIS IS NO DRILL"

This message, telling the US fleet that Pearl Harbor was under attack, was broadcast minutes after the raid began. It was no news to personnel already fighting for their lives.



AT DAWN ON DECEMBER 7, 1941, Japanese pilots for the first wave of the attack on Pearl Harbor climbed into their cockpits, each carrying a rations pack for the flight – rice and plums, chocolate, and pep pills. Propellers spun and engines roared into life as the leader of the attack, Commander Mitsuo Fuchida, donned the traditional *hachimaki* headband.

Despite a choppy sea, 183 aircraft took off without incident and formed up to set course for Oahu island, observing strict radio silence. For much of the flight there was low cloud. Fuchida corrected his bearing as he closed on the target by taking a fix on a music program broadcast by a Honolulu radio station – which also gave an update on local weather conditions. Then the cloud broke and the pilots were looking down on the lush green island. As Pearl Harbor came into view, Fuchida saw “the whole US Pacific fleet in a formation I would not have dared to dream of in my most optimistic dreams.” A total of 90 ships lay at anchor or in dry dock, including eight battleships. In the excitement of the moment, Fuchida radioed the carrier force with the signal for victory –

“Tora, tora, tora” – as the first strike went in, the torpedo-bombers skimming in low over the water and dive-bombers sweeping down from 12,000ft (3,500m). The air was thick with the smoke of explosions by the time the horizontal bombers, led by Fuchida, advanced in single file through anti-aircraft fire, while Mitsubishi A6M Reisen (Zero)

fighters swooped down to strafe the military airfields below. Almost 300 American planes were damaged or destroyed on the ground, and the Japanese had the air almost to themselves. In the midst of the mayhem, a flight of B-17 bombers arriving

from the United States were badly shot up.

The Japanese pilots were oblivious to the human drama unfolding on the ships and ground below, concerned only to carry out their tasks successfully. Many returned to their carriers in personal shame amid the general euphoria, convinced they had missed their targets, letting down their colleagues and their emperor. But Fuchida stayed over Pearl Harbor during the 170-plane second wave of the attack and was able to report to Admiral Nagumo on the damage caused. The admiral commented, “We may then conclude that anticipated results have been achieved.” That just about summed it up.

BLAZING WARSHIPS

A rescue launch attempts to pick up survivors from US warships surrounded by burning oil. Eighteen ships were sunk or severely damaged at Pearl Harbor, including five battleships. (This is a colorized version of a black-and-white print.)

“The moment has arrived.
The rise or fall of our empire
is at stake...”

ADMIRAL YAMAMOTO

MESSAGE TO THE FLEET BEFORE PEARL HARBOR

